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Original Page: 315**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1966**Coverage Date:** 1950-1966**Place Coverage**

G/wi, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): SOCIAL CONTROL

Other tasks of early training are also shared by the band, particularly by the segment in which the parents put themselves in each camp. Initially, the only punishment is the fuss caused by the baby's upsetting behavior, and the slight and short-lived lessening of the warmth of the affection of those who surround him. Later, after his third year, he is admonished to be more gentle and cooperative. When children misbehave, they are told to desist; if they persist, somebody will try to divert them into some more acceptable form of behavior. Physical punishment is rarely used, and then only consists of a slap or tap. To thrash or to beat a child would be regarded as savage and irrational; "if a child won't listen to you when you speak to him, he certainly won't do so when you beat him."

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The weaning process is described as "the child's growing tired of the breast." Solids are introduced into the infant's diet at an early stage as supplementary feeding and as material on which to cut emerging teeth. The supplementary component is gradually increased until, before his third year, the child is feeding himself and is given the breast only at fairly long intervals or when he needs comforting. The diminishing nutritional dependence on breast feeding and the desire to imitate older, weaned colleagues are probably the main factors terminating a child's desire for breast feeding. The initiative appears to come as much from the child as from the mother.

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After weaning, children no longer accompany their mothers everywhere, but are left in the care of an old man or woman who is camp keeper for the day. The children play together at games which are mostly imitations of adult activities, and also receive from the camp keeper informal instruction and

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advice on every topic that crops up. Child lore of adult activities is more accurate than is that of European children, and G/wi children's games are an effective part of training for adulthood. By the age of five, a child is expected to know the etiquette of avoidance and joking and no longer to seek bodily contact with parents except in times of emotional stress.

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When girls are old enough to manage the long walks, they occasionally leave the camp "school" and go out gathering with their mothers and the other women. They learn the skills involved in gathering food, and their socialization is furthered by listening to the uninhibited gossip and comments of the adult women.

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Boys' training in subsistence activities is mainly through playing games involving mock hunts, imitating older boys, and, around the fires at night, [316](#) listening to the men's conversation about their day's hunting. A father begins to take his son out on training hunts at ten or eleven, although instruction in the making, care, and use of weapons starts much earlier than this. It takes a long time to become a hunter, and a boy continues his training under the care of his father-in-law for several years after marriage.

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